

paradoxical question whether belief without reason may none the less be intellectually respectable, whether, although there are no reasons which would give a balance of direct support to theistic doctrines, there are reasons for not demanding any such reasons. Various arguments for this initially surprising thesis have been advanced by Pascal, Kierkegaard, and William James.

(a) *Pascal's Wager*²

Either God exists or he does not; but reason, Pascal says, is unable to decide the question either way. So you are forced to play a game of chance: you must, in effect, bet on one or the other. You cannot simply suspend judgement. Since it is a practical choice, you should consider what your various interests are. What you may stand to gain is knowledge of the truth and happiness; what you risk, if you should lose, is error and misery; the resources with which you wager are your reason and your will. There is no more damage to your reason if you bet one way rather than another, so it does not count. If you bet on God's existing, then, if it turns out that he does exist, you gain infinite happiness; while, if it turns out that he does not exist, you lose nothing. But if you bet on God's not existing, then, if it turns out that he does exist, you will have lost your chance of everlasting happiness; while, if it turns out that he does not exist, you gain nothing. So it is overwhelmingly practically reasonable to bet on God's existing, although you have no more intellectual reason to suppose that he exists than that he does not.

This is Pascal's first formulation of the choice before us; but he adds others. Perhaps it is not true that you lose *nothing* in betting on God's existing: you lose the worldly happiness that you could gain in this life if you were free from religious commitments. So, if you bet on God's existing, then, if you lose, you will have lost one happy life, while, if you win, you will have won an infinity of happy lives. But if you bet against God's existing, then, whether you win or lose, you will have only one happy life, while, if you lose, you will have lost the opportunity of an infinity of happiness. Pascal adds that he does not need to assume that the chance of God's existing is equal to the chance of his not existing. Even if the odds against his existing are n to 1, your expectation in betting on his existing, measured in units of happy lives, is infinity divided by $n + 1$, which is still infinity,

² B. Pascal, *Pensées*, in *Œuvres*, edited by L. Brunschvigg (Hachette, Paris, 1925), Section III, No. 233.

while your expectation in betting on his not existing is one such unit; so long as n is finite, the former is infinitely greater than the latter: 'il y a ici une infinité de vie infiniment heureuse à gagner, un hasard de gain contre un nombre fini de hasards de perte, et ce que vous jouez est fini'. The decision would become problematic only if n equalled infinity—that is, only if the odds against God's existing were infinite—so that the expectation in betting on God's existing were infinity divided by infinity, which is indeterminate.

The accompanying table, therefore, would express Pascal's final view of the betting problem.³ (Results and expectations are here measured in happy life units.)

<i>Bet on God's existing</i>	
Chance of winning $\frac{1}{n+1}$	Chance of losing $\frac{n}{n+1}$
Result of winning ∞	Result of losing 0
Expectation $\frac{\infty}{n+1} + 0$	
$= \frac{\infty}{n+1}$	
<i>Bet against God's existing</i>	
Chance of winning $\frac{n}{n+1}$	Chance of losing $\frac{1}{n+1}$
Result of winning 1	Result of losing 1
Expectation $\frac{n}{n+1} + \frac{1}{n+1}$	
$= 1$	

All this is a paraphrase of Pascal's argument, not an exact translation. It is clear that, given his assumptions, the argument goes through. Everything turns, therefore, on the acceptability of those assumptions. Of these the most basic is the very formulation of the problem as one of a practical decision in uncertainty. What, one might ask, would it be to wager that God exists? One can decide, on the grounds of various probable advantages and disadvantages, to act in one way or another, but can one, for such practical reasons, decide to believe something? Although there are voluntary actions, there seems to be no possibility of voluntary belief. However, Pascal has anticipated this objection. Perhaps, for the reasons he has given, you would like to believe in God but find yourself initially unable to

³ This is a modification of tables given in Notes on pp. 147–50 in the edition referred to in n. 2, p. 200, above.

do so. Since it is not reason that is now an obstacle to belief—for, by hypothesis, intellectual considerations were unable to settle the question either way, and practical reason, in view of the wager argument, favours belief—the obstacle must lie in your passions. You can work on these as others have done who have found the way to faith, by using holy water, having masses said, and so on: ‘Naturellement même cela vous fera croire et vous abêtira’. Although you cannot believe by simply deciding to do so, you can come to believe by deciding to cultivate belief. Indirectly voluntary belief is possible, though directly voluntary belief is not.

No doubt Pascal is right about this; but it goes against his earlier claim that to bet one way or the other about God will do no injury to your reason. Deliberately to make oneself believe, by such techniques as he suggests—essentially by playing tricks on oneself that are found by experience to work upon people’s passions and to give rise to belief in non-rational ways—is to do violence to one’s reason and understanding. As Pascal himself says, ‘cela . . . vous abêtira’: it will make you stupid. Others have put it more mildly: to acquire faith, you must become as a little child. But, however it is expressed, the point remains: in deliberately cultivating non-rational belief, one would be suppressing one’s critical faculties. Of course it will be said that to do this is to reject only a false reason, a superficial understanding, in order to attain a true wisdom, a deeper understanding. But to say this is to beg the question. We have as yet no reason to suppose that this ‘true wisdom’ is anything but a hopeful delusion, a self-deception. Nor could we come to have any reason to suppose this except by exercising those despised critical faculties.

Here, too, we should remember that in his discussion of the wager Pascal moves from the assumption that the odds for and against the existence of God are equal to the assumption that the odds against his existence are n to one, where n is any finite number. With the latter assumption, he is still able to argue that the expectation of happiness is greater in betting for than in betting against God’s existence; but he can no longer argue that there is no greater cost to one’s reason in the former than in the latter. To decide to cultivate belief in God, when, epistemically, the odds are n to one against his existing, and n is some large number, is deliberately to reject all rational principles of belief in uncertainty. There is, in Pascal’s proposal, a real cost which he has tried to conceal.

Still, it may be thought that even if this cost is properly allowed for, the case for a practical choice based on comparative expectations

holds good. But here we must bring out, and challenge, his other assumptions. He considers only these alternatives: first, that there is a god who will reward with everlasting happiness all those who believe in him for whatever reason, and, secondly, that there is no god and that one's existence simply ends completely when one dies. But obviously there are other possibilities. One, to which a Christian thinker might well have paid some attention, is that people are predestined to salvation or to non-salvation—perhaps to damnation—no matter what they now decide, or try to decide, to do. If so, nothing one does now will make any difference with regard to one's prospects for an afterlife, so one should try to do whatever gives the best chance that the present life will be happy. Another possibility is that there might be a god who looked with more favour on honest doubters or atheists who, in Hume's words, proportioned their belief to the evidence, than on mercenary manipulators of their own understandings. Indeed, this would follow from the ascription to God of moral goodness in any sense that we can understand. The sort of god required for Pascal's first alternative is modelled upon a monarch both stupid enough and vain enough to be pleased with self-interested flattery. Again, even if there were a god of Pascal's sort, there are various sub-possibilities to be taken into account: perhaps this god is not satisfied with the mere belief that there is *a* god, but adopts the principle *nulla salus extra ecclesiam*, where the church within which alone salvation is to be found is not necessarily the Church of Rome, but perhaps that of the Anabaptists or the Mormons or the Muslim Sunnis or the worshippers of Kali or of Odin. Who can say? From the position of initial ignorance and non-reliance on reason in which Pascal starts, no such possibility is more likely than any other.

Once the full range of such possibilities is taken into account, Pascal's argument from comparative expectations falls to the ground. The cultivation of non-rational belief is not even practically reasonable. Indeed, the true position is the exact opposite of what he has presented. Whereas Pascal says that speculative reason is neutral with regard to the existence of a god, and that belief must therefore, and can, be based on practical reason alone, the truth is rather that practical reason is here neutral, and that we can and must therefore do the best we can with speculative reason after all.